means, they say, that instead of coding a significant portion of a spoken language, the script only represents ‘nonlinguistic symbols of political and religious significance’. This has been robustly challenged by Parpola and other scholars. The Harappans certainly knew about the Mesopotamian Cuneiform writing system, so they knew the value of a script. Perhaps theirs was not a full but a partial writing system. Even such basic matters remain unresolved.

It’s unclear how the script will finally be deciphered, unless we chance upon a bilingual text for its inscriptions—a Rosetta Stone of sorts. If such a thing exists, it may be in Mesopotamia, where the Harappans traded actively. I personally hope their inscriptions turn out to be a script that encodes vivid information, and that it gets deciphered in my lifetime, revealing the Harappans based on their own words and unlocking more of their mysteries for us.

One afternoon, the younger guide takes me to the quarry from where ancient Dholavirans mined the beautiful multihued stones found all over their city. We ride his 100-cc motorcycle, going north on unpaved hilly, stony roads through arid scrubland. After seeing the quarry, we continue north, looking for an unexcavated Harappan mound, one of a few on Khadir. This region is under close surveillance by the Border Security Force (BSF), especially since the terrorist attack in February 2019 in Pulwama, Kashmir. We learn from a passing jeep of BSF jawans that to go further we’ll need permission from a faraway office, a process that might take weeks and possibly end in denial.

But when the jawans disappear from sight, we push on, risking the consequences. On one uphill stretch of rocky terrain, the bike stalls and tips over. We fall but escape lightly, with just a knee abrasion in my case. I’m soon drawn to an enchanting quality in this part of the island, to its undulating hills and the great views it offers over the gleaming white Rann. The terrain is also rich in fossils and variously coloured and textured stones. When we stop to wander up a slope, I stash a few seashell fossils in my pocket. A couple of miles later, perhaps shaken by the fall, the guide gets cold feet, raises the spectre of detection by the BSF, and advises that we turn back.

What’s clear is that Dholavirans engaged in an epic struggle against the elements. Their entire city strived to wrestle order out of a hostile